



Roasted Garlic *and* Olive-Stuffed Chicken Breasts

FOR THE ROASTED GARLIC

4 garlic heads
Extra-virgin olive oil, as needed

FOR THE STUFFED CHICKEN BREASTS

2 tablespoons unsalted butter
3 tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil
5 ounces (140g) shiitake mushrooms,
cleaned, trimmed, and finely chopped
¼ red onion, thinly sliced
½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper
1 (6-ounce/170g) jar pitted green olives,
drained and chopped
1 cup (113g) crumbled feta cheese
1 teaspoon ground fennel seeds
½ teaspoon kosher salt
4 boneless, skinless chicken breasts
1 lemon
Chopped fresh parsley, for serving

My childhood family dinners were oftentimes the product of new dishes and techniques that my mom had learned from her books. One of her favorites was Chicken à la Archduke, or stuffed chicken breast. It made me realize that the perfect antidote to Plain Jane chicken was butterflying, stuffing, and baking it. Here I call for roasted garlic and olives, but you could experiment with any of your favorite herbs and aromatics. **SERVES 4**

MAKE THE ROASTED GARLIC: Preheat the oven to 400°F.

Cut the tops off each head of garlic to expose the cloves and remove any loose skin on the outside. Place the heads in the center of a piece of foil and drizzle lightly with olive oil. Scrunch up the foil over the garlic and seal to create a packet.

Place the garlic packet on a baking sheet and roast for 40 minutes, until the cloves are very tender. Carefully open the foil and let the garlic cool completely. The roasted garlic heads can be stored whole in an airtight container for up to 2 weeks. You can also squeeze out the cloves, place in a jar, cover with olive oil, and store in the refrigerator for up to 1 month.

MAKE THE STUFFED CHICKEN BREASTS: In a 12- or 14-inch nonstick skillet over medium-high heat, melt the butter with 1 tablespoon of the olive oil. Add the mushrooms and cook, stirring occasionally, until they start to release their moisture and reduce in size by about half, 5 to 8 minutes. Add the red onion and ¼ teaspoon of the pepper and cook for 5 more minutes, until the onions are softened and the mushrooms start to brown.

Transfer the mushroom mixture to a bowl and add the chopped olives. Squeeze the cloves from one head of the roasted garlic into the bowl and add ¾ cup of the feta. Stir to combine.

In a small bowl, combine the ground fennel seeds, salt, and the remaining ¼ teaspoon of black pepper. Set aside.

Place the chicken pieces on a cutting board. Starting on the thickest side, use a paring knife to carefully cut a pocket into the side of each piece, cutting about three-quarters of the way through the chicken. Sprinkle the outside and the pocket of the chicken with the fennel seed mixture.

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Stuff each of the pockets with about $\frac{1}{4}$ cup of the mushroom mixture, securing the opening with a toothpick if needed. (You will have some filling left.)

In the same skillet, add the remaining 2 tablespoons of olive oil and swirl to coat the bottom of the pan. Place the chicken breasts in the pan.

Cook over medium heat without disturbing until well browned, about 14 minutes. Carefully flip each piece and sprinkle the remaining stuffing mixture around the chicken breasts in the pan. Continue cooking until the chicken is browned and an instant-read thermometer registers 165°F when inserted into the thickest portion of the chicken, about 14 minutes more. After flipping, you can partially cover the pan if it appears the center of the chicken isn't cooking through. Remove the pan from the heat.

Sprinkle the remaining $\frac{1}{4}$ cup of the feta around the pan. Zest the lemon over the chicken, cut it in half, and squeeze the juice over the pan. Garnish with chopped parsley.

TIPS & TRICKS

Cutting pockets into the chicken breast fillets versus butterflying the fillets holds the filling best. Place a fillet on a cutting board. Running a small knife into the thickest side, make a 3- to 4-inch slit down the length of the fillet. Continue making shallow cuts into the fillet following the shape of the chicken piece. This should leave the fillet intact on three sides and create a cavity in the middle.

To reinvent leftovers, chop the chilled, stuffed chicken into small pieces and combine with mayonnaise, sour cream, red onion, and celery, then season with salt and pepper for an incredibly tasty chicken salad.